

Blog Stub Template

Openable in four minutes, publishable in one hour

1 What the stub is for

Question 36 states the problem and does not need restating: one or two hours a week are available for blogging, and without a stub to open, that hour goes to reading around while the thought stays suspended at the top of your mind and then vanishes.

The site already runs on stubs. Of the twenty-three pages under `content/overview/blogs`, eight carry a body. Thirteen are front matter and a title. Two sit in between: one holds a link and nothing else, one holds a single paragraph in italics. Four of the thirteen give *Stay tuned...* as their description.

So the practice exists. What it lacks is a shape and an order, so that the hour lands on writing rather than on deciding what the page is. Both are recoverable from the eight pages that are finished, because those eight agree with each other.

2 The shape, read off the finished pages

The six environment pages, the section front page above them, and the dictionary front page use the same ten parts in the same order. Not every page carries every part, and the ones that skip a part skip it from the bottom.

1. **Description**, in the front matter. One sentence, and it is the page's whole promise. The dictionary page uses it to state why the dictionary exists at all: "To collaborate is to communicate, to communicate is to cross the bridges of misunderstandings."
2. **Icon**, in the front matter. One name from the set GitBook offers.
3. **Title**. Two or three words. The name of the thing, nothing more.
4. **The gloss**. One bold line directly under the title saying what the thing is. All six environment pages have one.
5. **Figure and caption**. Five of the six have one. The caption is a verdict rather than a label: "Hard to search, quick to finish. Both at once." "Three axes, six environments. No single ordering." "Real hosts, simulated wire, real telemetry."
6. **Body**. Two to four paragraphs. The longest of the eight runs four.
7. **The verdict line**. Bold lead-in, then the use: *****Use it for*****, and where it applies, *****Don't use it for*****. Two of the six put a role in place of a use, naming the page's subject as the source or the far target of a transfer experiment.
8. **Publications**, under the italic lead-in *_Work of mine that runs on this environment._* Five of the six have one. The sixth replaces it with a ***## Related*** section pointing at the page where its question is taken up.

9. **Collaborators**, the same five pages, photo and affiliation per person.
10. **Footer**. `_Last updated: 2026-08_` on all eight.

Then one more part, which is not on the page: a line in `content/SUMMARY.md`. Without it the page is a file and not a page.

3 The stub itself, three fields

Three fields, two of them from the list above and one the standalone post supplies. The body is not among them.

Description. The sentence you would give a colleague who asked what the post is about, before you have written any of it.

Title. Two or three words.

The one sentence. The thought that made you want the page. Written down in the shape it arrived in, including as a question.

The third field is the whole point and it is the one a stub usually skips. A page that has only a title is a filename with an intention attached, and a week later the intention no longer says what you meant. The interdisciplinary research post is the counter-example on the site: it has no body, and it holds an entire essay anyway, because its description names three things it will cover and its one italic paragraph asks the question the essay is about, starting “It’s shocking, sometimes, to realize that there **are** solutions.”

Stay tuned... is the description of last resort. It is honest, and it is also the sign that the thought was not written down while it was still there.

4 The skeleton

Copy this into a new `.md` file. Everything below the third field is optional at stub time and every line of it is a prompt rather than a requirement.

```
---
description: [one sentence, the promise of the page]
icon: [font-awesome-name]
---

# [Two or three words]

_[The one sentence. The thought, in the shape it arrived in.]_

**[The gloss: what this thing is, in one line.]**

<figure><figcaption><p>[Caption as a
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    verdict, not a label.]/p></figcaption></figure>

[Body paragraph. What it is and how it works.]

[Body paragraph. What it costs, or what it gets wrong.]

**Use it for** [the case where it is the right choice].

**Don't use it for** [the case where it is not].

## Publications

_Work of mine that runs on this environment._

[table: badge | paper and venue | authors | link]

## Collaborators

[table: photo, name, affiliation, one cell per person]

_Last updated: 2026-08_

```

Three lines in that skeleton stay and the rest can go. The description, the one sentence, and the footer. A page without the footer looks abandoned rather than unfinished, which is a different and worse thing.

5 The fill order, and what fits in an hour

The order is not the order the parts appear in. Write the short fixed-cost parts first, because they are the ones that decide what the body has to say.

Part	What it costs	When it gets written
Description	one sentence	the minute the thought arrives
Title	seconds	same minute
The one sentence	one sentence	same minute
Gloss	one line	first hour
Verdict line	one or two lines	first hour
Caption	one or two short sentences	first hour
Body	two to four paragraphs	second hour
Figure	an asset to make	after the body, if at all
Tables	copied from a sibling page	last
SUMMARY.md line	one line	last

Write the verdict before the body. The verdict line is the sentence the post exists to deliver, and once it is on the page the body has something to reach. Writing it last means writing the body without knowing where it ends, which is how two paragraphs become six.

The caption is the second draft of the verdict. Every caption on the finished pages is two short sentences, or one sentence and a three-word correction after it. If the caption will not compress to that, the verdict is not sharp yet, and the body will not fix it.

Publish at the verdict line. A page with a description, a title, a gloss and a verdict is a page. It reads as short rather than as unfinished, and the body can arrive the following week.

6 Three kinds of page, three skeletons

Deciding which kind takes a few seconds and saves the rest of the hour.

The catalog entry. One member of a set the reader is comparing. The six environment pages. Gloss, figure, body, verdict, publications, collaborators. Its job is to be comparable to its siblings, so the parts stay in the same order and carry the same headings even where a page has nothing to put under one.

The section front page. Sits above a set and says what the set is for. The cyber environments page opens “Every claim about an autonomous cyber agent is a claim about the environment it was measured in.” Then a figure, then the one paragraph naming the tension that makes the set worth reading as a set, then the linked list of children, then the footer. No tables. The children carry those.

The standalone post. No set, no siblings, no comparison. Description that carries the outline, one epigraph in italics, body. No tables, no verdict line. The interdisciplinary research post is this kind, and so is the PSRO post waiting to be written.

7 Registration, and the asset names

Three mechanical steps, all of them cheap and all of them easy to forget.

1. Add the page to `content/SUMMARY.md` at the indentation of its siblings. Nesting in that file is what produces the sidebar tree.
2. Put images in `content/.gitbook/assets/` using the prefixes already in use: `env-` for an environment animation, `badge-` for a venue or paper badge, `collab-` for a person. A page two levels below `content` reaches them at `../../.gitbook/assets/`.
3. Copy the publication and collaborator tables from a sibling page rather than writing the markup. They are wide, they are fiddly, and the column widths are already tuned.

8 When a stub may stay a stub

For as long as you like. Thirteen of twenty-three have stayed stubs and the site is not worse for it, because a stub with a description is a promise the reader can read and decide about.

The one rule is the one the site already breaks in four places: a stub may not stay without a description. That is the field that costs a sentence and holds the thought, and it is the only part of the page that cannot be reconstructed later from the title.

9 Sources

- The ten parts, the order, the three page kinds, and every quoted line are read off the blogs tree on the site, `content/overview/blogs/`: the section front page and the six environment pages carry the body, the dictionary front page carries the description quoted in section 2, and the interdisciplinary research post carries the description-as-outline.
- The counts are of the twenty-three files in that directory as they stand in August 2026.
- The registration step and the asset prefixes are read from `SUMMARY.md` and from the assets directory beside it.
- The problem the template solves, and the hour budget it is built around, are stated in question 36.